Composting at home

Composting turns kitchen scraps and yard waste into dark, crumbly soil that your garden plants love. You only need a bin, or a simple pile in a shady corner of the yard.

Build the pile in layers. Add "greens", such as vegetable peelings, coffee grounds and grass clippings, and "browns", such as dry leaves, cardboard and shredded paper. Aim for about two parts brown to one part green. Keep the pile as damp as a wrung-out sponge, and turn it every week or two so air reaches the microbes doing the work.

Leave out meat, dairy and oily food. They attract rats and flies and make the pile smell. If the pile is slimy and sour, add more browns. If it is dry and nothing is happening, add water and some fresh greens.

In warm weather the compost is ready in two to three months, when it smells like forest soil and you can no longer recognize the scraps. Spread a thin layer over vegetable beds or mix it into potting soil.